Aetna Interview Prep: Hybrid XD + Content Design

Question-and-answer study guide · Written in first person for a portfolio conversation

Portfolio examples to use: Sendory for structured content and reusable templates; IreTV for plain-language hierarchy and empathetic decision support; Meridian/API Launchpad for technical content, documentation, and progressive disclosure; Forma for design-system and accessibility patterns; FlowNode for AI-assisted interaction and transparent system feedback.

1. Question	Answer
At JPMorgan Chase, how did you structure content frameworks and plain-language messaging alongside visual design when translating complex financial rules for consumers?	I started by separating the rules from the user decision. I worked with research, product, legal, and subject-matter partners to identify what a person needed to know, what they needed to do, and what could be safely deferred. I then created a content hierarchy, plain-language labels, helper text, validation, and error guidance alongside the wireframes. **Sendory** is a useful portfolio example because I treated reusable content blocks and templates as part of the product system, not as copy added at the end. My goal was always to make the next decision clear while preserving the accuracy of the underlying rule.

2. Question	Answer
How do you ensure Figma component libraries account for structural UX patterns and dynamic content structures such as localization and content-length variability?	I design the component and the content model together. In Forma, I defined reusable patterns for navigation, forms, records, dialogs, media, and status. For each pattern I think through short and long labels, empty and error states, longer translated strings, assistive-technology labels, and responsive behavior. I document the content rules in the component guidance so engineers know what is flexible, what is required, and what should never be truncated. That keeps the design system useful beyond the ideal English example.

3. Question	Answer
How have you used Claude, Figma Make, or custom AI workflows to accelerate journey mapping or content drafting without losing human-centered quality?	I use AI to accelerate exploration, not to make the decision for me. I use it to cluster notes, generate edge cases, draft alternative labels, and turn a workflow into prototype states. In FlowNode, for example, I explored how an AI-generated workflow could be explained, edited, approved, and recovered from failure. I still validate the language against user goals, technical constraints, accessibility, and domain expertise. I do not treat generated text or synthetic findings as research evidence.

4. Question	Answer
Your background is in banking and financial services. How will you adapt your design and content process to healthcare terminology and regulatory guardrails?	The domain changes, but the method transfers. I would learn the member journey, terminology, plan rules, and regulatory constraints with researchers, clinicians, operations, legal, and compliance partners. My finance experience has taught me to make risk, eligibility, permissions, and exceptions understandable without hiding complexity. I would establish a shared glossary, content review checkpoints, and evidence-based language standards, then test whether members can understand what applies to them and what to do next.

5. Question	Answer
Can you share an example where you partnered with engineers to build scalable structured content templates or content models?	Sendory is the closest portfolio example. The product is built around reusable newsletter components, elements, and templates that let someone compose a consistent publication without rebuilding every layout. I approached the work as a system: define the content structures, the allowed combinations, the states, and the rules for maintaining hierarchy. I would use the same approach in an enterprise CMS: model content by purpose and reuse, document fields and constraints, and partner with engineering on authoring, rendering, QA, and release behavior.

6. Question	Answer
Given your recent executive titles, how do you balance strategy with hands-on wireframing, UI copy, and edge-case documentation?	I stay close to the work. I use strategy to frame the right problem, then I move into flows, wireframes, prototypes, content, and handoff details. My portfolio reflects that range: Meridian and API Launchpad show complex workflow modeling; Forma shows system-level structure; Sendory shows content and reusable templates. I am comfortable moving between a leadership discussion, a Figma file, a content review, and an engineering working session when that is what the product needs.

7. Question	Answer
Tell us about a time usability testing or heuristic evaluation showed that legal or business requirements were creating friction. How did you gain buy-in while preserving clarity?	I treat the requirement and the friction as separate problems. I first make the user failure visible with a task, quote, prototype, or completion measure. Then I work with legal and product to understand the purpose of the requirement and look for a clearer way to meet it: better timing, progressive disclosure, plain language, or a more useful explanation of the consequence. The conversation becomes ‘how do we preserve the protection and help the user understand it?’ rather than ‘design versus legal.’

8. Question	Answer
Healthcare journeys can happen during stressful, high-stakes moments. How do you use empathetic content strategy to reduce cognitive load?	I reduce the number of decisions a person has to make at once. I use clear headings, familiar language, short instructions, meaningful status, and a visible next step. I explain why information is needed and what will happen after a choice. I also design for uncertainty: missing information, eligibility questions, unavailable services, and handoffs should have calm, specific guidance. IreTV demonstrates this kind of content hierarchy, while Meridian shows how progressive disclosure can make a complex workflow easier to complete.

9. Question	Answer
How do you handle critique when partners disagree about whether a friction point is visual or content-related?	I bring the team back to the task. We look at what the user is trying to understand or do, where they hesitate, and what evidence we have. Then I test both dimensions: simplify the content, adjust the hierarchy, change the interaction, or try a combined solution. Content and layout are often inseparable. I prefer a quick prototype or usability check over debating personal preference, and I document the decision and the reason behind it.

10. Question	Answer
With your MBA in Business Analytics and design-operations background, how do you measure the business impact of unified content and experience design?	I connect the design goal to a behavior and a business outcome. For a member journey that might be task completion, self-service success, reduced repeat contact, fewer errors, or faster resolution. I would establish a baseline, define the success measure with product and analytics, and combine behavioral data with research so we do not optimize for speed at the expense of comprehension or trust. My role is to make the connection between content quality, experience quality, and measurable product performance visible.

11. Question	Answer
Walk us through one project from beginning to end.	I would use Sendory or Meridian. I start with the problem and audience, then explain the research partnership, the key insight, the content and interaction decisions, the prototype, validation plan, and handoff. I keep the story focused on how one decision led to the next rather than showing every artifact.

12. Question	Answer
What exactly did you own on the project?	I make ownership explicit. I owned the UX framing, information architecture, flows, interaction design, content hierarchy, prototype, and design rationale. I partnered with research on evidence, product on priorities, engineering on feasibility, and subject-matter or compliance partners on accuracy and risk.

13. Question	Answer
Show us where content changed the design.	In Sendory, the content model shaped the product because reusable blocks had to work across different newsletter types and lengths. That affected the component structure, authoring flow, hierarchy, and preview behavior. I treated the content rules as part of the interaction design rather than adding copy after the layout was finished.

14. Question	Answer
How do you decide between a tooltip, helper text, page content, or an error message?	I place guidance where the user needs it. Critical information belongs in the flow. Helper text supports a decision before input. Errors explain what happened and how to recover. Tooltips are for optional clarification, not information a person must know to complete a high-risk task.

15. Question	Answer
How would you improve a confusing healthcare form?	I would first map the full task and identify where people hesitate, abandon, repeat information, or misunderstand eligibility. I would simplify the sequence, group related questions, use plain-language labels, explain why sensitive information is needed, and make errors specific and recoverable. I would test comprehension and completion, not just visual preference.

16. Question	Answer
How do you write for people who may be stressed, sick, or unfamiliar with insurance?	I reduce the number of decisions at each step. I use familiar words, direct headings, short instructions, visible progress, and a clear next action. I explain consequences without using fear or unnecessary jargon, and I provide calm recovery guidance when information is missing or a service is unavailable.

17. Question	Answer
How do you work with legal or compliance when they prefer exact language?	I start by understanding the purpose and risk behind the requirement. Then I preserve the legal meaning while improving the user experience through hierarchy, timing, labels, examples, and progressive disclosure. I use a prototype or usability evidence to make the trade-off concrete instead of framing it as design versus legal.

18. Question	Answer
What do you do when research and stakeholder opinion conflict?	I look at the quality and relevance of the evidence, return to the user task, and name the uncertainty. If the decision is still unclear, I propose a focused usability check or content comparison. That gives the team a way to resolve the disagreement through evidence rather than hierarchy or personal preference.

19. Question	Answer
Tell us about a design critique that changed your direction.	I treat critique as a way to improve the decision, not defend the first version. I restate the original assumption, identify what the feedback revealed, and explain the change. For complex workflows, feedback often leads me to clarify hierarchy, expose a hidden state, or reduce the amount a user must understand at once.

20. Question	Answer
How do you handle accessibility in content?	I consider accessibility in the structure and language: meaningful headings, descriptive link labels, readable error messages, predictable focus order, text paired with color, clear status announcements, and instructions that do not depend on visual assumptions. I review content with accessibility partners and test the interaction states, not only the static screen.

21. Question	Answer
How do you design content for mobile and web together?	I preserve the same user intent, terminology, and decision logic, then adapt the experience to the device. Mobile may need shorter steps, stronger prioritization, touch-friendly controls, and less simultaneous information. Web can support more comparison and reference content. The content model should support both without creating contradictory guidance.

22. Question	Answer
What do you know about CMS or structured content?	I think in reusable fields, modules, rules, ownership, localization, versioning, QA, and release behavior. Sendory is the closest portfolio example because the product is organized around reusable newsletter components and templates. I would partner with content and engineering to define the model, document authoring guidance, and verify that content renders correctly across channels.

23. Question	Answer
What would you do in your first 30, 60, and 90 days?	In the first 30 days I would learn the member journeys, content ecosystem, design system, metrics, and review process. By 60 days I would audit a priority journey, identify friction and content gaps, and align on a measurable opportunity. By 90 days I would deliver or validate one focused improvement and establish a repeatable collaboration model with product, research, engineering, accessibility, and compliance.

24. Question	Answer
What is a growth area for you?	My deepest domain experience is in regulated financial products rather than healthcare. I am addressing that by learning the member journey, terminology, plan and eligibility concepts, and regulatory context with subject-matter experts. The transferable strength I bring is making complex rules understandable and designing carefully within constraints.

25. Question	Answer
Why Aetna and why this hybrid role?	The role brings together the parts of design I do best: content clarity, interaction design, complex journeys, systems, research partnership, and collaboration with engineering and compliance. I am interested in healthcare because the quality of the experience can directly affect whether people understand their options and get the help they need.

26. Question	Answer
What would you do if you had one day to improve an experience?	I would identify the highest-risk user decision, review the current flow and content, and choose one change that could reduce confusion immediately. I would prototype the revised hierarchy and language, review it with the relevant partners, and define the smallest test that would tell us whether the change improved comprehension or task completion.

27. Question	Answer
How would you approach a short design or content exercise?	I would clarify the audience, goal, constraints, channel, and success measure before designing. Then I would sketch the journey and content hierarchy, identify edge cases, and make a low-fidelity direction visible quickly. I would explain my assumptions, invite critique, and show how I would validate the design before polishing it.